

THE HAPPINESS ISSUE

Nestled in the sugarcane fields of Satara, about 250 kilometres south of Mumbai, is a gurukul unlike any else. Students wake up at 6 am, recite prayers and, an hour later, converge on the ground, where, wielding bows and arrows, they start aiming for the bullseye 50-70 metres away. The range may not be a levelled, manicured lawn as seen abroad, and harsh sunlight and seasonal rain can play spoilsport. But nothing deters these young archers from their targets. It's what Pravin Sawant, who runs Drushti Archery Academy, had dreamt of all along—a place where *shishyas* (students) eat, pray and love archery.

Pravin, who is now 32, took up archery after chancing on the sport on TV during the 2008 Olympics. He was then working as a ward boy in a hospital in Satara and, after finishing his night shift, he would travel to Wai, 35 km away, to train. "At first, I took up the game to land a job; then, I realised there's a lot more to it," says Pravin. "Archery *sukoon deta hai* [gives me a sense of tranquillity]." A national school games champion in compound archery in 2010, Pravin did land a job as a police constable, but repeating the success on a bigger platform proved harder due to financial constraints. He considered giving coaching a shot and started Drushti Archery Academy in 2017.

It took Satara a while to take to archery. Drushti's president Sujeet Sharad Shedge, a renowned *malkhamb* practitioner, recalls how people saw it more as an archaic pursuit. Finding a permanent space was also tough until Mahendra Kadam, Pravin's acquaintance from the hospital days, parted with an acre of his farmland to make way for the gurukul in 2021. "This is the *garh* [bastion]. We have to take the game forward," says Shedge. "Right now, we are running on a no-profit, no-loss model."

Drushti's modest hostel currently accommodates around 20 students, but given its accomplishments in 2023—four Asian Games gold medals and three world championship gold medals between Ojas Pravin Deotale, 21, and Aditi Swami, 17, both of whom recently received the Arjuna Award—the interest is growing. "A big reason why people want to come here is that we adhere to the *guru-shishya parampara* and Pravin stays here and focuses on students," says Shedge.

In the past two years, Drushti has housed aspirants not only from Maharashtra but even Haryana and Chandigarh. Kolhapur's Netra Manish Sahara, 18, is one such acolyte who moved to the gurukul after Class 12 to realise her quest to represent India in the Olympics. "Two months in," she says, "it almost feels like home." The students have to pay Rs 1,000 as a monthly training fee besides Rs 1,500 for lodging.

What it lacks in scale and splendour, Drushti makes up with the zeal of its students, the youngest being Pravin's five-year-old daughter named after the academy. Archery is an expensive pursuit—a compound and recurve set costs Rs 1.5-3 lakh. The academy steps up to help students who are talented but economically challenged.

But a visit to a training centre in Switzerland has made Pravin value how much he has accomplished with the bare minimum. "After [producing] two Arjuna awardees," he says, "Satara deserves an international-level ground." Satara had also given India its first individual Olympic medallist—wrestler Khashaba Jadhav, who won a bronze in 1952. Pravin seeks to add to that tally, having started training in recurve, which, unlike compound, is an Olympic discipline. "Our work will not stop," he says. "I couldn't experience the 52-second high [when the national anthem plays during the podium ceremony], but my students are experiencing it." ■

HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

- **Based on the *guru-shishya parampara*, this academy produced India's first world champions in archery—Aditi Swami, 17, and Ojas Pravin Deotale, 21—in 2023**
- **Besides another 50+ state/ national champions, it has helped six archers land government jobs through sports quota**